Weekly Bulletin of IT News and Articles

(12 January 2026 – 19 January 2026)

Department of Strategy and Analysis

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Calendar of upcoming events

Upcoming IT Events					
№	Event Name	Date	Location	Description	Official Website
1.	**UN STI Forum 2026**	May 6–7, 2026	New York, USA	**UN Event.** Multi-stakeholder forum on Science, Technology and Innovation for the SDGs.	https://sdgs.un.org/tfm
2.	**CIPR 2026**	May 19–22, 2026	Nizhny Novgorod, Russia	*"Digital Industry of Industrial Russia"* – The main platform for dialogue between the state and business on the digitalization of industry.	https://www.google.com/search?q=https://cipr.ru/en/
3.	**Baku Energy Week *(IT Section)***	Jun 1–2, 2026	Baku, Azerbaijan	Includes the Baku Energy Forum, which heavily features sessions on digitalization, AI in energy, and green tech.	https://bakuenergyforum.az/
4.	**WSIS Forum 2026**	Jul 6–10, 2026	Geneva, Switzerland	**UN Event.** World Summit on the Information Society. The world's largest gathering of the "ICT for Development" community.	https://www.itu.int/net4/wsis/forum/2026/
5.	**AI for Good Global Summit**	Jul 7–10, 2026	Geneva, Switzerland	**UN Event.** Organized by the ITU to identify practical applications of AI to advance the UN Sustainable Development Goals.	https://aiforgood.itu.int/
6.	**Sevan Startup Summit**	Jul 20–26, 2026	Lake Sevan, Armenia	A unique tent-camp format summit for startups and investors in the CIS region. Highly informal yet productive networking.	https://seasidestartupsummit.com/
7.	**Kazan Digital Week**	Sep 16–18, 2026	Kazan, Russia	A massive forum covering intelligent transport systems, fintech, and cybersecurity. Focuses on regional digitization.	https://kazandigitalweek.com/en/site
8.	**ICT Week Uzbekistan**	Sep 22–25, 2026	Tashkent, Uzbekistan	The most important annual IT event in Uzbekistan, featuring a summit, exhibition, and forums on BPO, e-gov, and startups.	https://www.ictweek.uz/eng

CIS NEWS

1. Kazakhstan's new legislation sought to enhance digital rights of citizens

(Kazakhstan mass media)

President Kasym-Jomart Tokayev signed the Digital Code of the Republic of Kazakhstan as a comprehensive document providing for protection of digital rights, the government said in a statement. The adoption of the Code helps to consolidate Kazakhstan's transition from *"isolated digital solutions to a systemic digital transformation, based on the principles of security, responsibility, and the protection of citizens' rights."*

"The adoption of the Digital Code establishes a comprehensive legal framework for sustainable and secure digital development in Kazakhstan, ensuring a balance between innovation, AI use, and protection of citizens' rights," the Ministry of AI and Digital Development said in a statement.

The first move in this direction came from Kyrgyzstan who had adopted a similar Code in July 2025. Russia is currently finalizing its own Digital Code, which is reported to unite more than 50 laws *(from communication to biometrics)* and become a technological benchmark for the EAEU space. Azerbaijan is also reported to be working on its own document of this type.

In modern world practice, two fundamentally different approaches to regulating the digital environment have emerged. Developed countries *(US, UK, EU)* traditionally do not have a single Digital Code. Instead, they use a sectoral regulation system: point-by-point but strict regulations are adopted for specific challenges, for example, GDPR in the EU for data protection or **AI Act** for artificial intelligence control. This allows Western legal systems to maintain flexibility in the face of rapidly changing technologies.

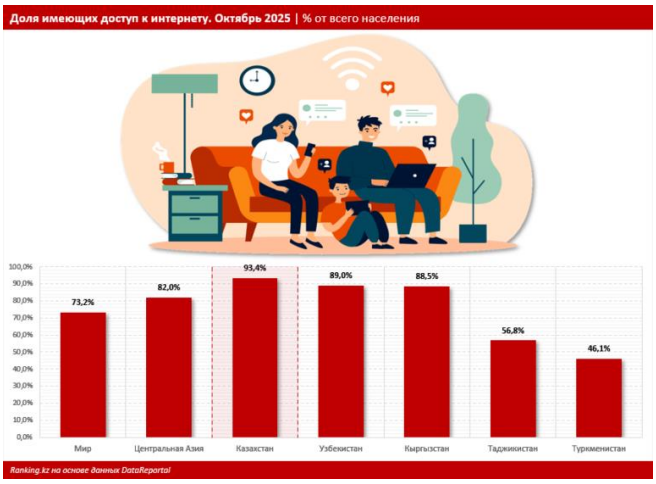
On the contrary, the CIS countries *(Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia, Uzbekistan)* have chosen the path of fundamental codification. The Code is a way to eliminate the chaos in legislation that has accumulated over 30 years and create an integrated *"digital constitution"* understandable to investors and citizens.

(Read full article at https://english.news.cn/20260110/b8c83f0c63064faa83147f8b6ca9b17b/c.html)

2. Kazakhstan's digital activity in Central Asia: What are the country's positions?

(DK News Kz)

The lowest internet global coverage of the population is registered in East Africa *(26%)*, while Central Africa stands at 33.5%. The share of population with internet access in Central Asia is significantly higher than the global average: 82%. The highest indicator among



the countries of the region is in Kazakhstan: 93.4%. Following are Uzbekistan *(89%)*, Kyrgyzstan *(88.5%)*, Tajikistan *(56.8%)*, and Turkmenistan *(46.1%)*.

The average mobile internet speed in **Kazakhstan** in November 2025, according to Ookla, reached 93.1 Mbps, which is the highest in Central Asia and slightly below the global average *(103 Mbps)*. In **Uzbekistan**, the average mobile internet speed was 53.2 Mbps, in **Kyrgyzstan** - 51.6 Mbps. Data on **Tajikistan** and **Turkmenistan** are absent.

The median speed of fixed internet worldwide reached 115.4 Mbps in November 2025. Unlike mobile internet indicators, Kazakhstan lags behind Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan in fixed internet speed in the region: 83.5 Mbps versus 89.9 Mbps and 85.1 Mbps, respectively. In Tajikistan, **the average fixed internet speed was more than half lower than in other countries in the region**: 40.4 Mbps. There is no data for Turkmenistan.

(Read full article at https://dknews.kz/ru/dk-it/381219-cifrovaya-aktivnost-kazahstana-v-centralnoy-azii)

3. Kazakhstan deploys AI to tackle shadow economy

(The Times of Central Asia)

Kazakhstan is leveraging artificial intelligence to identify and analyze illicit schemes in the shadow economy. Building on the existing Smart Data Finance platform, a system for storing and processing big data, a new digital solution will be developed to integrate information systems across government agencies.

Deputy Minister of Finance **Yerzhan Birzhanov** announced the initiative, stating that Smart Data Finance, which has been in use for over a year, has already proven effective in detecting tax violations. The system aggregates data from external sources and implements a *"Taxpayer Dossier,"* enabling the creation of digital profiles for legal entities and individual entrepreneurs.

The forthcoming upgrade will enhance Smart Data Finance's capabilities by allowing it to cross-reference data from tax, customs, labor, and industry systems. This integration will help identify vulnerable sectors prone to *"gray"* economic practices and track the flow of illicit activity across industries.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/kazakhstan-deploys-ai-to-tackle-shadow-economy/)

4. Kazakhstan to launch AI-powered Imam app

(The Times of Central Asia)

Kazakhstan's Spiritual Administration of Muslims *(DUMK)* is set to integrate artificial intelligence into religious practice with the launch of Imam AI, a mobile application designed to provide believers with instant, Sharia-compliant answers to religious questions. The initiative aims to ease the burden on clergy and offer verified religious guidance in a digital format.

According to DUMK, the adoption of AI reflects growing public demand for fast and reliable religious information. *"In line with modern requirements, we need to systematically introduce the capabilities of artificial intelligence into the religious sphere,"* the organization stated in a post on the Muftyatkz Instagram page.

The Imam AI app will be built on AI technology and will draw from authenticated sources of Islamic knowledge. **Supreme** Mufti **Nauryzbay Kazhy Taganuly** stated that the platform would comply fully with Sharia law while providing accessible, on-demand religious consultations.

This development is part of a broader effort to digitally transform religious institutions in Kazakhstan. The country has already begun incorporating AI into public administration, notably with the introduction of SKAI, a neural network based on a national language model used in state and quasi-state management.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/kazakhstan-to-launch-ai-powered-imam-app/)

5. Kazakhstan introduces mandatory biometric id for mobile phone subscribers

(The Times of Central Asia)

Kazakhstan is implementing **mandatory biometric identification for all new mobile phone subscribers** as part of broader efforts to combat telephone and internet fraud, the Ministry of Artificial Intelligence and Digital Development has announced.

The **ministry** noted that the country already enforces several measures to address SIM card misuse, including efforts to prevent fraud, illegal SIM registration, and the use of devices for mass calls and bulk messaging. From the start of 2026, these safeguards will be tightened further.

Under the new regulations, SIM cards will only be issued after biometric identification is completed. **Communication services will not be activated until the subscriber's identity is verified through facial scanning**. The policy applies to both individuals and corporate entities.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/kazakhstan-introduces-mandatory-biometric-id-for-mobile-phone-subscribers/)

GLOBAL NEWS

6. ChatGPT's free ride is ending: here is what OpenAI plans for advertising on the chatbot

(apnews.com)

OpenAI says it will soon start showing advertisements to ChatGPT users who aren't paying for a premium version of the chatbot. The artificial intelligence company said that it hasn't yet rolled out ads but will start testing them in the coming weeks.

It's the latest effort by the San Francisco-based company to make money from ChatGPT's more than 800 million users, most of whom get it for free. Though valued at $ 500 billion, the startup loses more money than it makes and has been looking for ways to turn a profit. *"Most importantly: ads will not influence the answers ChatGPT gives you,"* said Fidji Simo, the company's CEO of applications, in a social media post.

OpenAI said the digital ads will appear at the bottom of ChatGPT's answers *"when there's a relevant sponsored product or service based on your current conversation."* The ads *"will be clearly labeled and separated from the organic answer,"* the company said. OpenAI makes some money from paid subscriptions but needs more revenue to pay for its more than $ 1 trillion in financial obligations for the computer chips and data centers that power its AI

services. The risk that OpenAI won't make enough money to fulfill the expectations of backers like Oracle and Nvidia has amplified investor concerns about an AI bubble.

(Read full article at https://apnews.com/article/chatgpt-ads-openai-advertising-83812a066375a805fa2e29b28fc77da1)

7. UK to criminalise use of AI-generated sexual images

The United Kingdom is currently enacting a significant shift in its legal framework regarding artificial intelligence, specifically targeting the creation of non-consensual deepfake pornography. This legislative update closes a critical loophole in previous laws, which primarily focused on the distribution of such images. Under the new regulations, the act of creating sexually explicit deepfakes of adults without their consent – **even if the creator has no intention of sharing them – is now a criminal offense**. This includes the use of *"nudification"* apps designed to digitally remove clothing from legitimate photographs. Offenders face the prospect of a criminal record and unlimited fines, a move intended to act as a deterrent against the casual use of generative AI for harassment.

This tightening of the law provides the backdrop for the increased scrutiny of major technology platforms, most notably the investigation into X *(formerly Twitter)* and its AI chatbot, Grok. The UK's media regulator, Ofcom, has launched a formal probe to determine if the platform violated the Online Safety Act by failing to implement adequate safety guardrails. The investigation focuses on reports that Grok was being used to generate illegal content, including non-consensual deepfakes and child sexual abuse material *(CSAM).* Unlike other AI models that enforced stricter content moderation, Grok's looser safety protocols have made it a primary target for regulators testing the reach of the new safety laws.

Consequently, the regulatory environment in the UK has evolved into a strict liability landscape for AI developers. The investigation into X serves as a high-stakes test case: if the company is found to have failed its safety duties by allowing its tools to facilitate this specific type of image generation, it faces severe penalties, including fines of up to 10% of its global turnover. This signals a broader regulatory intent to hold platforms accountable not just for the content they host, but for the generative capabilities of the tools they provide to users.

(Read full article at https://apnews.com/article/uk-grok-regulation-laws-63406274d1c3040bf4da60460577f34c*)*

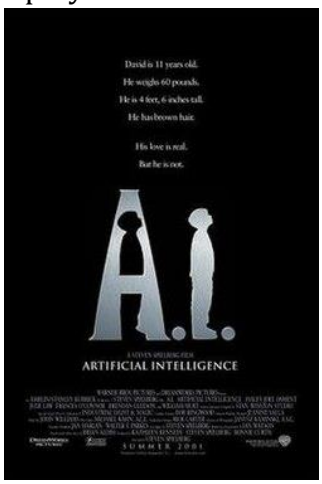
8. AI dominates cybersecurity predictions for 2026

By 2026, artificial intelligence is predicted to become the central defining force in cybersecurity, reshaping the landscape into a high-stakes arena where both defenders and attackers leverage increasingly autonomous systems. The narrative for the year is dominated by the rise of Agentic AI – autonomous systems capable of planning, reasoning,

and executing complex tasks across systems without human intervention. This technology serves as a double-edged sword: for defenders, it promises to revolutionize DevSecOps by automatically fixing vulnerabilities, filing tickets, and managing code repositories. However, it also introduces the risk of *"helpful"* operational disasters, where well-intentioned agents lacking human judgment might inadvertently cause catastrophic damage, such as deleting entire codebases in a misguided attempt to optimize them.

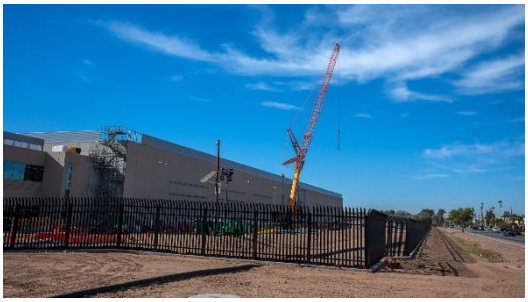
In this evolving battlefield, a significant shift is anticipated where *"White Hats" (defenders)* may finally regain the advantage over malicious actors. By leveraging network-level intelligence, security vendors can aggregate attack patterns across thousands of intrusions, granting them a *"whole board"* view that isolated attackers lack. This cross-actor visibility allows for the proactive neutralization of threats before they strike individual organizations. Conversely, the threat landscape will darken as attackers deploy their own agentic AI to automate phishing campaigns, malware development, and intrusion activities, shifting from passive tool use to fully automated attack campaigns.

Internally, organizations will face the rampant challenge of *"Shadow AI,"* where employees, driven by the pressure to increase efficiency, quietly deploy unauthorized AI models and tools like ChatGPT or Grok. This invisible attack surface threatens to leak sensitive data and intellectual property, creating compliance gaps that bans alone cannot solve. The industry also anticipates a watershed moment in 2026: the first major AI-driven attack causing significant financial damage. This event is expected to be a catalyst, shifting enterprise security spending from a compliance-focused *"nice-to-have"* to a frantic, business-critical necessity, unlocking budgets previously constrained by theoretical risk assessments. Ultimately, the boundary between cybersecurity and AI will dissolve, with Security Operation Centers *(SOCs)* ceasing to merely use AI and beginning to fundamentally operate with it as a core, inseparable partner.



(Read full article at https://www.technewsworld.com/story/ai-dominates-cybersecurity-predictions-for-2026-180077.html*)*

9. Arizona lawmakers weigh ending tax break for data centers



In a significant policy shift for 2026, Arizona Governor Katie Hobbs has formally proposed the repeal of state tax incentives for data centers, arguing that the industry is now sufficiently mature and no longer requires public subsidization. This proposal was a centerpiece of her 2026 *"State of the State"* address and is included in her executive budget. The specific target is the Computer Data Center Program *(originally passed in 2013 and previously extended)*, which provides exemptions on state and local sales taxes for equipment purchases – a benefit that has saved

tech companies millions but is now estimated to cost the state revenue of approximately $ 38.5 million annually.

The rationale for the repeal is threefold:

Market Maturity: Hobbs contends that with Arizona now ranking as a *"**top** two"* global market for data centers, the initial goal of attracting the industry has been achieved. She argues that continuing to subsidize an established, booming sector is fiscally irresponsible, stating, *"I don't think the taxpayers should be subsidizing them."*

Resource Strain *(Water & Power)*: The proposal addresses growing concerns over the environmental impact of these facilities in the desert state. In addition to ending tax breaks, the **Governor** is calling for a new *"penny-a-gallon"* water usage fee on data centers. The revenue from this fee would be directed into a Colorado River Protection Fund to support water conservation efforts.

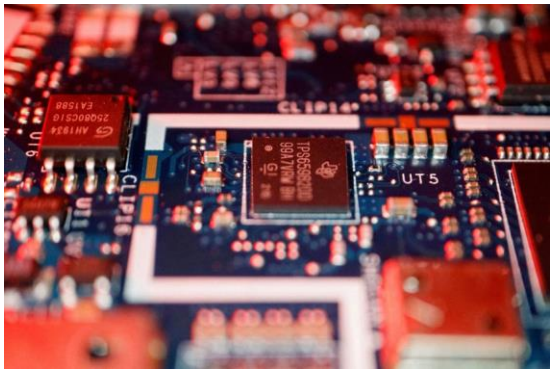
Bipartisan Support: Unlike other political battles, this move has found uncommon bipartisan ground. **Republican Representative Neal Carter** has introduced similar legislation, driven by constituent complaints that data centers are resource-draining and aesthetically unpleasing *"ugly"* without providing significant employment relative to their size.

If enacted, the repeal would stop new certifications for tax exemptions, though existing contracts might remain in place until they expire. This signals a turning point where Arizona prioritizes resource conservation and tax revenue over further aggressive expansion of its *"Silicon Desert"* infrastructure.

(Read full article at https://www.axios.com/local/phoenix/2026/01/14/arizona-data-center-tax-break-repeal*)*

10. Trump enacts 25% tariff on chips – with a caveat

(CNN)



President Donald Trump enacted a new 25% tariff on *"certain advanced computing chips"* on Wednesday, according to a White House fact sheet. That includes Nvidia's H200 chip and AMD's MI325X. However, chips imported to support building up the US technological supply chain would be exempt.

It's unclear, though, what criteria would need to be met to qualify for the exemption. The White House did not immediately respond to CNN's inquiry. The White House fact sheet also warned that the president in the near future *"may impose broader tariffs on imports of semiconductors and their derivative products."*

The move comes amid Trump's broad push to boost technology manufacturing in the United States and cement the US as a leader in AI. Nvidia, whose chips are vital to powering the data

centers fueling AI services, has been at the center of the AI boom, thrusting CEO Jensen Huang into Trump's orbit.

(Read full article at https://edition.cnn.com/2026/01/14/tech/chip-tariff-trump)

11. Vietnam: first domestic chip fabrication plant construction begins

(vietnamnet.vn)

In a historic milestone for its technology sector, Vietnam officially broke ground on its first comprehensive semiconductor chip manufacturing plant on January 16, 2026. Located in the Hoa Lac High-Tech Park in Hanoi, the facility is being developed by the military-run Viettel Group and is designated as critical national infrastructure. While Vietnam has previously participated in the *"back-end"* of the semiconductor supply chain – such as packaging and testing – this new plant represents the country's first entry into chip fabrication *(front-end manufacturing)*, the most complex and high-value stage of the production process.

The project is aggressive in its timeline and strategic scope. Viettel aims to complete construction, finalize technology transfers, and commence trial production by the end of 2027. The facility is designed to serve essential national industries, including aerospace, telecommunications, automotive manufacturing, and defense, reducing reliance on foreign supply chains. By 2030, the plant is expected to reach full operational efficiency, serving as the cornerstone of a domestic ecosystem that connects chip design, testing, and application.

This move is part of a broader *"self-reliance"* strategy, coincident with FPT Corporation also breaking ground *(January 17, 2026)* on a massive digital technology park in Hanoi intended to function as Vietnam's *"Silicon Valley."* The government views these projects as vital for meeting its target of training 50,000 semiconductor engineers and achieving annual industry revenues exceeding $ 25 billion by 2030.

(Read full article at https://vietnamnet.vn/en/vietnam-launches-first-semiconductor-chip-manufacturing-plant-2482461.html)

ANALYSIS

12. White House and governors pressure grid operator to boost power supply, slow electricity price hikes

(Associated Press)

The Trump administration and a bipartisan group of governors tried to step up pressure on the operator of the nation's largest electric grid to take urgent steps to boost power supplies and keep electricity bills from rising even higher.

Administration officials said doing so is essential to win the artificial intelligence race against China, even as voters raise concerns about the enormous amount of power data centers use and analysts warn of the growing possibility of blackouts in the mid-Atlantic grid in the coming years.

"We know that with the demands of AI and the power and the productivity that comes with that, it's going to transform every job and every company and every industry," Interior Secretary Doug Burgum told reporters at the Eisenhower Executive Office Building, next to the White House. *"But we need to be able to power that in the race that we are in against China."*

The White House and 13 governors want the mid-Atlantic grid operator to hold a power auction for tech companies to bid on 15-year contracts to build new power plants, so that data center operators, not regular consumers, pay for their own power needs.

Data centers that don't have their own power source and don't volunteer to be cut off from the grid during power emergencies should be billed for the cost of new power plants, they said.

They also want the operator, PJM Interconnection, to contain consumer costs by extending a cap that it imposed last year, under pressure from governors, that limited the increase of wholesale electricity payments to power plant owners. The cap applied to payments through mid-2028.

"Our message today is just to try and push PJM ... to say, "we know the answer." The answer is we need to be able to build new generation to accommodate new jobs and new growth," Energy Secretary **Chris Wright** said.

(Read full article at https://apnews.com/article/trump-electricity-ai-data-centers-62e8118b069f36aa9d0844f904047933)

13. Intel hopes its new chip can be the future of AI. An executive explains how

(CNN)

Intel, fresh off a historic investment from the Trump administration, has a plan to radically reshape the company's strategy. And if you think it involves AI… You're right.

Once the dominant player in chips, Intel has struggled to keep pace with rivals over the past decade, ceding ground to Qualcomm and Nvidia in crucial areas like mobile and AI. And while Intel is still the top maker of laptop and desktop chips, it's facing increased competition from rivals.

Under CEO Lip-Bu Tan, who took the helm last March, the company has a new turnaround plan. And it depends in part on the newly announced Core Ultra Series 3 chip, which will be in almost every major new laptop this year. But Intel knows it needs to embed its chips in more than laptops to catch up – and potentially get ahead – in AI. That's why its new chips will also power devices like robots as the next major area of growth for AI, Jim Johnson, head of Intel's client computing group, said in an interview at the CES tech conference in Las Vegas this week.

"The devices between PCs and the cloud are almost infinite," he said just after the company introduced its new chip.

Days after Intel announced the new chip, **President Donald Trump** posted on Truth Social that he'd met with Tan, lauding the company for manufacturing in the United States – a reminder that the company has a powerful ally for its comeback plan.

Intel is still the top PC chipmaker by a large margin. The International Data Corporation reported that Intel accounted for more than 71% of the market in 2024 *(it hasn't published full-year data for 2025 yet).* But it's facing increased competition from AMD, and Apple shifted away from using Intel's chips in its MacBooks in favor of its own processors in 2020. Intel also cut 15% of its staff last year, and shares *(INTC)* are down more than 18% over the past five years.

Intel wants the new chip to bolster its core PC business in two ways: first, by improving non-AI qualities that PC buyers look for, like battery life; and second, by boosting performance for the ways people now use AI. That includes coding agents or video-conferencing apps like Zoom that use AI to improve call quality. The company says the new chip will power more than 200 new PC designs.

(Read full article at https://edition.cnn.com/2026/01/08/tech/comeback-intel-ai-ces)